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Russian President Vladimir Putin, left, and Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi pose for a photo at the Palam Air Base in New Delhi yesterday.

Handshake, car ride and high stakes as Modi hosts Putin

Indian PM gives warm welcome as nation weighs US pressure and Russia deals

DUBAI
BY STEPHEN N.R.
Senior Associate Editor

Russian President Vladimir Putin landed in New Delhi yesterday for a two-day visit aimed at deepening defence, energy and trade ties even as India faces mounting pressure from Washington over its continued purchase of Russian oil.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi personally received Putin at Palam airport, greeting him on the red carpet with a handshake and a warm embrace be-

\$68.7b
bilateral trade in last fiscal year, but heavily in Russia's favour

fore the two leaders left together in the Prime Minister's car — a display of personal rapport at a sensitive geopolitical moment.

Putin, on his first trip to India since the start of the Ukraine war, is accompanied by Defence Minister Andrei Belousov amid expectations of progress on major military deals, including additional S-400 air defence systems and a possible offer to co-produce Russia's Su-57 fifth-generation fighter jets. "The range of our cooperation

with India is huge," Putin told *India Today*, citing nuclear energy, space and shipbuilding.

Bilateral trade reached \$68.7 billion last fiscal year, but remains heavily skewed in Russia's favour, driven largely by discounted crude imports. India's exports were just \$4.88 billion, prompting New Delhi to seek greater market access for pharmaceuticals, automobiles and services. The two nations are targeting \$100 billion in trade by 2030, but fresh US sanctions on Russian oil firms Rosneft and Lukoil have already reduced Indian crude purchases.

Experts warn of ramifications on ongoing trade negotiations with Washington to reduce the 50 per cent tariffs, if Modi signs major energy or defence agreements with Moscow this week.

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US widens social media vetting for H-1B visas

REVIEW TO NOW INCLUDE SKILLED FOREIGN WORKERS AND THEIR FAMILIES

DUBAI
BY NIVETHA DAYANAND
Assistant Business Editor

The US Department of State will extend its online presence review to all H-1B visa holders and their dependents beginning December 15, marking the latest tightening of digital vetting measures for foreign nationals seeking entry into the country.

The review, previously applied to student and exchange visitor categories under F, M, and J visas, will now include skilled foreign workers and their families.

Officials said the move reflects the government's broad approach to national security screening in the visa issuance process.

In a notice released on December 3, the Department instructed all H-1B and H-4 applicants to adjust their social media privacy settings to "public" to facilitate the review.

Online presence review

"The Department will expand the requirement that an online presence review be conducted for all H-1B applicants and their dependents, in addition to the students and exchange visitors already subject to this review," the statement said.

A senior State Department official noted that the updated process aims to ensure that

The Department emphasised that each visa adjudication represents 'a national security decision', reinforcing the administration's continued reliance on digital footprints to assess applicants' credibility and intent.

"those applying for admission into the United States do not intend to harm Americans and our national interests."

The Department emphasised that each visa adjudication represents "a national security decision," reinforcing the administration's continued reliance on digital footprints to assess applicants' credibility and intent.

US visa 'a privilege'

"We conduct thorough vetting of all visa applicants, including online presence review of all student and exchange visitor applicants in the F, M, and J nonimmigrant classifications," the statement added.

Officials underscored that access to a US visa remains a privilege contingent on clear evidence of eligibility and lawful intent.

"A US visa is a privilege, not a right," the statement concluded.

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